

FREE HOST GUIDE

Better listing photos

A practical guide to help guests notice, understand and trust your short-term rental before they book.

FOR HOSTS LISTING ON

Airbnb

Booking.com

Vrbo

First Look Photo

firstlook-photo.com

First Look Photo is an independent photography service and is not affiliated with, endorsed by or sponsored by Airbnb, Booking.com or Vrbo.

Read it with your listing open

About eight minutes. Not a photography course — you won't need a camera.

1 Open your listing on a phone

Not on a laptop. Most guests will meet your property on a small screen first.

2 Work through the two tools

The Cover Photo Test and the Gallery Audit are the parts to actually complete.

3 Change one thing at a time

You don't need a full reshoot to make your listing clearer. Start with what costs nothing.

BEFORE WE START

What photos can and cannot do

Better photos can make a listing clearer, more trustworthy and easier to choose.

They cannot guarantee bookings, ranking or revenue. Those depend on price, location, season, reviews and demand as much as on presentation.

SO THIS GUIDE PROMISES ONE THING

That by the end you will know what to look at, what to change first, and what is not worth changing at all.

Nothing here is a platform rule or an inside track. It is one host's judgment, applied to photographs.

THE FIRST LOOK

Guests don't see your property first.

They see your photos first.

Before a guest reads your amenities, checks your reviews or opens your description, your photos have already made an argument.

In a few seconds they decide whether to keep looking or move on.

THE IDEA BEHIND THIS GUIDE

Your property may be better than your listing shows. The goal is not to make it look different. It is to show its real value more clearly.

WHERE PHOTOS WORK

A listing is a journey, not a folder

Photography carries most of the weight at the start. The rest of the journey depends on it being honest.

Attention

Interest

Booking

Experience

Review

Trust

Photography mainly supports the first two stages.

It cannot fix a stay that does not match the images — which is exactly why the photos have to stay true to the property.

Not every photo has the same job

Each position in the gallery does something different for the guest.

1 Your cover photo

STOP THE SCROLL

Give a guest a reason to stop and explore instead of scrolling past.

2 Your first five

BUILD INTEREST

Explain quickly why the property is worth considering.

3 The rest

REMOVE UNCERTAINTY

Answer the quiet questions. Is there space? Is it clean? Where do I cook?

TRY THIS NOW

Look at your first five photos

Open your listing and look only at the first five images. Nothing else.

Ask what each one helps the guest understand.

If two of them say the same thing, one is taking a position it has not earned.

EVERY PHOTO SHOULD EARN ITS PLACE

A photo should attract, explain, differentiate, reassure or create desire. Repetition without a job just adds noise.

TOOL 1

The cover photo test

Your cover photo is not the prettiest image you have. It is the one that earns the click.

Look only at it, and answer honestly. Seven questions over the next two pages.

THE MOST USEFUL HABIT IN THIS GUIDE

Don't judge your cover photo full-screen. Judge it small. That is how most guests will actually see it for the first time.

✓ **Is it immediately clear what I'm showing?**

A guest should understand the space in about a second.

✓ **Does it show one of the best reasons to book?**

If your strongest feature is photo twelve, many guests never reach it.

✓ **Is there one clear place for the eye to go?**

A view, a bed, a table by the window. Not everything at once.

✓ **Does the light feel natural and inviting?**

Not brighter than reality — just the property on a good day.

✓ **Is anything distracting in the frame?**

Cables, bins, clutter, a reflection of the camera.

✓ **Does it hold up next to my competitors?**

Search your area and dates, and compare thumbnails side by side.

✓ **Does it still work small?**

Most guests meet your listing as a thumbnail, not a full-screen image.

SCORING

If you hesitated on more than two, your cover photo is probably the first thing worth changing.

LESSON 1

Light and colour

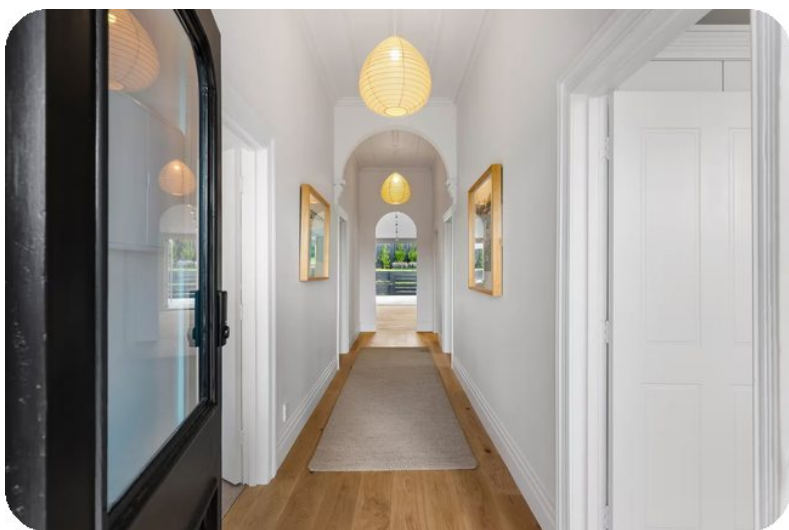
Colour temperature is the problem hosts notice least and guests feel most.

Warm indoor bulbs mixed with daylight can leave white walls looking beige, and a renovated space looking older than it is.

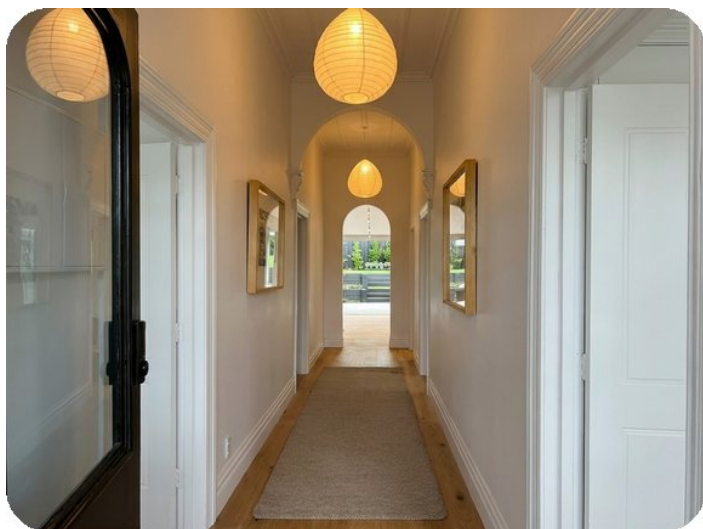
THE PRINCIPLE

The goal isn't to make the property brighter than reality. It's to make it look like reality on a good day.

LESSON 1 • EXAMPLE



BEFORE



AFTER

Same hallway, same hour, same furniture. Correcting the white balance lets the walls read as white and the floor as timber. Nothing added, nothing removed.

MINI-ACTION

Check your walls

Open two photos of the same room taken at different times of day.

If the walls are a different colour in each, colour is doing something you have not chosen.

This is the cheapest fix in the whole guide, and usually the most visible.

LESSON 2

Where the camera stands

Before editing a photo that isn't working, ask whether it was taken from the right place.

Moving the camera usually changes more than editing can.

THE USUAL CULPRITS

Camera too high or too low · too much wall, floor or ceiling · furniture cut in half at the frame edge · leaning verticals · a portrait crop that hides how the space connects.

LESSON 2 · EXAMPLE



BEFORE



AFTER

Above, the sofa arm fills the foreground and the room has to be guessed at. Below, a landscape frame lets the guest read the whole space: where you sit, eat and cook.

MINI-ACTION

Take two steps back

Stand where you took your worst-performing photo.

Take two steps back and one step to the side. Take it again in landscape.

Compare the two. Most of the time the second one explains the room better — and you changed nothing about the room.

Before editing a bad photo, ask whether it was taken from the right place.

LESSON 3

Remove before you add

Good styling is mostly subtraction. Before buying anything, take away what the guest does not need to see.

Then set the scene with what the property already has.

COSTS NOTHING, CHANGES A LOT

Hide cables · clear countertops · remove cleaning products · straighten chairs and pillows · put away personal items · check for reflections in glass · align curtains.

LESSON 3 · EXAMPLE



BEFORE



AFTER

The bare table above shows furniture. The table below shows dinner. Same room, same crockery — a guest can now picture an evening in it.

THE HONEST LIMIT

Style with what guests get

If a detail appears in the photos, it should be part of the stay.

Otherwise it stops being styling and becomes an expectation you have to meet — every single booking.

BETTER PRESENTATION IS NOT FALSE EXPECTATION

A photo that oversells today is a review problem in three weeks.

Don't photograph rooms. Photograph the stay.

Every property has a reason people choose it over the one next to it. Sometimes the host knows exactly what it is.

Often it is hiding in the reviews.

A QUESTION WORTH ANSWERING BEFORE YOUR NEXT SHOOT

Why would somebody book here instead of the place next to it? If you can answer that in one sentence, you know what your first three photos should be.

It might be any of these

- ✓ A view worth waking up for
- ✓ Outdoor space, a deck or a garden
- ✓ A genuinely comfortable bed
- ✓ A kitchen people will actually cook in
- ✓ A quiet place to work for a week
- ✓ Room for a family or a group
- ✓ Walking distance to something
- ✓ One detail nobody else has

Mini-action

Read your last ten reviews and highlight every noun a guest mentions without being asked — the light, the bed, the deck, the walk. That list is your shot list.

What not to fake

Editing and AI-assisted enhancements can improve light, colour, clarity, composition and cleanup. Used well, they help the photo represent the property accurately.

Used badly, they create an expectation the stay cannot meet — and the guest writes about it afterwards.

THE RULE WE WORK TO

Improve the image. Don't invent the property.

Reasonable

- ✓ Exposure and brightness
- ✓ Colour and white balance
- ✓ Straightening verticals
- ✓ Sensible cropping
- ✓ Recovering window detail
- ✓ Removing a stray cable or bin

Not reasonable

- Adding amenities that don't exist
- Changing the layout or architecture
- Making rooms look materially bigger
- Inventing a view
- Replacing the furniture

The gallery audit

Tick only what is honestly true today.
Leaving boxes empty is the useful part.

- ☐ The cover photo would stop me if it weren't mine
- ☐ The best reasons to book appear in the first five images
- ☐ Every important room and space is represented
- ☐ No two photos are doing the same job
- ☐ Light and colour look consistent across the gallery

TOOL 2 · CONTINUED

- ☐ Each room is easy to understand from a single image
- ☐ The amenities guests care about are actually visible
- ☐ The photos look realistic, not over-edited
- ☐ Small distractions have been cleared out of frame
- ☐ The sequence tells a clear story of the stay

YOUR SCORE

_____ / 10

It is not a grade — it is a shortlist.

What to do next

8–10

Your gallery is doing its job

Leave it alone. Revisit the cover photo seasonally.

5–7

There are real opportunities

Usually the sequence, the cover photo, or the light and colour. Fix the order first — a remote upgrade can often finish the rest without a full session.

0–4

The photos are holding the listing back

Preparation alone will not close this gap.

These three cost nothing

- 1 Move your strongest image to the front
- 2 Delete the photos that repeat something you have already shown
- 3 Tidy and reshoot the one room you like least

AND ONE HONEST NOTE

If your photos are already doing the job, I would rather tell you that than sell you a session you don't need.

You can do this yourself

TODAY, FOR FREE

- Cleaning and tidying
- Decluttering surfaces
- Making beds properly
- Curtains, blinds and lamps
- Removing personal items
- Reordering your gallery

Harder to fix afterwards

WHERE A SESSION EARNS ITS PLACE

- ✓ Camera position and framing
- ✓ Lens choice and perspective
- ✓ Straight verticals
- ✓ Bright windows with dark interiors
- ✓ Consistent colour across a gallery
- ✓ Which image should lead

WHERE THE LINE IS

Preparation has a ceiling

Preparation can improve a photograph a great deal. Cleaning, tidying and ordering your gallery cost nothing and often change the most.

What preparation cannot do is rescue a photograph taken from the wrong place, in the wrong light, at the wrong moment.

THE HONEST SUMMARY

Preparation can improve a photo.
Preparation cannot completely
rescue the wrong photograph.

BEFORE YOU CHANGE ANYTHING

The five-minute exercise

- 1 **Open Airbnb or Booking.com on your phone**
- 2 **Search your area with realistic dates**
- 3 **Find your own listing in the results**
- 4 **Don't open it**
Stay on the results page.
- 5 **Compare your cover photo with the ones around it**

THEN ASK YOURSELF

Which one would I click first?

If I knew nothing about these properties — no reviews, no prices, no descriptions — which one would I click first?

This forces you to stop seeing your property as an owner and start seeing it as a product in a market.

IF THE ANSWER ISN'T YOURS

You have learned something useful, and it cost you five minutes.

IF YOU'D LIKE A SECOND OPINION

Send me your listing

I'll look at your cover photo, your first five images, the light and the order of the gallery, and tell you what I would change first.

If your photos are already doing the job, I'll tell you that instead.

Get my free photo review

firstlook-photo.com

No cost, no obligation, and no follow-up sequence you have to unsubscribe from.

IF A SESSION ISN'T THE ANSWER

Try a remote upgrade first

Not every listing needs a full session. If the photos just need correcting, I can improve them remotely.

- ✓ Light, colour and white balance correction
- ✓ Straighter verticals, cleaner perspective
- ✓ A recommended photo order

\$49

Founding price for the first ten listings (usually \$99).

Start with a free photo review

I'll tell you if this is enough, or if you need a session.

WHEN THE PHOTOS ARE THE PROBLEM

Book a focused session

A session at your property, realistic editing, and guidance on which image should lead and how the gallery should be ordered.

Short-term rental work only — no generic real-estate galleries.

Book a photo session

Dates and availability by arrangement

Either way, you keep this guide.



Brian

I photograph short-term rentals — apartments, houses and holiday homes. I'm also a host, which is why this guide talks as much about sequence, expectations and reviews as it does about light.

Every listing gets looked at personally before a session is booked.

GET IN TOUCH

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DISCLAIMER

This guide is for general educational purposes. Results vary by property, location, season, pricing, reviews, demand and platform behaviour. Better photos can improve clarity and presentation, but they do not guarantee bookings, ranking, revenue or review outcomes. First Look Photo is not affiliated with Airbnb, Booking.com or Vrbo.



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